

Go on a Cognate Hunt

Thousands of words your students already know.

Why it works

About a third of academic English has a close relative in Spanish. Students do not notice cognates automatically; they have to be taught to look. Once they do, a page of science or history text stops looking foreign.

How to do it

- 1 Teach the three big endings.**
-tion is -ción, -ity is -idad, -ly is -mente:
nation, nación; activity, actividad; rapidly, rápidamente.
- 2 Hunt before reading.**
Give students two minutes to circle every word that looks like Spanish.
- 3 Check the trap.**
Ask, "Does it mean the same thing?" Most do. A few do not.

In your subject

ELA	narrator / narrador · conflict / conflicto · metaphor / metáfora
Math	triangle / triángulo · fraction / fracción · multiply / multiplicar
Science	organism / organismo · gravity / gravedad · reaction / reacción
Social studies	colony / colonia · revolution / revolución · economy / economía
False friends	actual means real, not current · sensible means reasonable, not sensitive · embarrassed is not embarazada

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Circles cognates and says both words aloud.	Emerging Sorts circled words into same meaning and different meaning.	Progressing Uses three cognates from the text in sentences.	Challenge Finds the pattern: lists five more -tion / -ción pairs.
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Try it this week

Before one reading this week, run a two-minute cognate hunt. Post the three endings and leave them up.

What a visitor would see

Students circling words before they read, and an endings chart on the wall.

Word Walls That Work

If nobody points at it, it is wallpaper.

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Why it works

A word wall helps only when students use it while they talk and write. The walls that work are small, current, visual, and touched every day. Twelve words students actually use beat sixty they never look at.

How to do it

- 1 Keep it to this unit.**
Ten to fifteen words. Take the old ones down.
- 2 Add a picture and a cognate to each.**
A quick sketch counts. Let students make the cards.
- 3 Make students use it.**
"Use one wall word in your answer." Point to it when you say it.

What it looks like

Organize by meaning	Group words that go together: processes, tools, people, results.
Add the word's partners	evidence: strong evidence, provide evidence, evidence shows
Make it reachable	Low enough to read from every seat, in print large enough to copy.
Give it a job	Exit tickets must include two wall words, underlined.
Retire words	Move mastered words to a "We own these" list. Students love watching it grow.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Points to the word and its picture.	Emerging Copies the word into a frame.	Progressing Uses the word with its partner phrase.	Challenge Adds a new word and teaches it to the class.
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Try it this week

Cut your word wall to this unit's words. Add a sketch to each. Require two wall words in every exit ticket.

What a visitor would see

A short, current word wall with pictures, and students glancing at it while they write.

Teach the Word Parts

One root unlocks twenty words.

Why it works

Students meet thousands of new academic words a year, far more than anyone can teach one at a time. Word parts are the shortcut, and most Greek and Latin roots are shared with Spanish, so English learners often have a head start.

How to do it

- 1 Pick the part that repeats in your subject.**
One prefix, root, or suffix per week is plenty.
- 2 Build a family.**
Write the part in the middle and let students add every word they know.
- 3 Predict, then check.**
“If geo means earth, what might geothermal mean?”

In your subject

ELA	auto (self), bio (life), graph (write): autobiography
Math	poly (many), equi (equal), meter (measure): equilateral, perimeter
Science	photo (light), hydro (water), therm (heat): photosynthesis
Social studies	demo (people), cracy (rule), migr (move): democracy, migrate
Any class	un-, re-, pre-, dis-, -tion, -able cover a large share of all prefixed and suffixed words.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Matches the word part to a picture or gesture.	Emerging Sorts words into families by part.	Progressing Predicts the meaning of a new word from its parts.	Challenge Collects words with the part from other classes.
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Try it this week

Choose one word part that appears all over your current unit. Build its family on the board with the class.

What a visitor would see

A word family web on the board that students add to during the week.

Read the Question First

Reading with a purpose is a different activity.

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Why it works

Strong readers know what they are looking for before they begin. Many English learners read every word at the same slow speed because nobody told them what mattered. Reading the question first tells them where to spend their effort.

How to do it

- 1 Read the question aloud before the text.**
Students underline what it asks them to find.
- 2 Have them restate it.**
"Tell your partner what you are looking for."
- 3 Read, then return to the question.**
Students mark the place in the text where they found it.

In your subject

ELA	"You are reading to find out how Tomás changes. Mark where he changes."
Math	"Underline the question in the word problem. Circle what you are solving for."
Science	"Read to find two causes of erosion. Number them in the text."
Social studies	"Read to find out why the author opposed the law. Mark his reasons."
Any class	Put the question at the top of the page, not the bottom.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Hears the question read aloud and points to a key word.	Emerging Underlines what the question asks for.	Progressing Restates the question and marks the answer in the text.	Challenge Writes a second question the text could answer.
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Try it this week

For every reading this week, read the question aloud first and have students restate it before they read.

What a visitor would see

Questions posted before the reading, and students marking the text where they find answers.

Annotate with a Purpose

Three marks, not a rainbow.

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Why it works

Highlighting everything is the same as highlighting nothing. A short, fixed set of marks gives students something to do while they read and gives you a window into their thinking. Notes in the home language are welcome; they are notes, not the final product.

How to do it

- 1 Teach three marks.**
A question mark for confusion, a star for important, an arrow for connections.
- 2 Model on the first paragraph.**
Think aloud for one minute while you mark.
- 3 Talk from the marks.**
"Find one question mark and ask your partner about it."

What it looks like

? confusion	A word or sentence I do not understand yet.
★ important	Something that answers the question I was given.
→ connection	This connects to another part, another class, or my own life.
Margin notes	Two or three words, in any language. Translations of key words are fine.
After reading	Question marks become the class discussion. Nothing is more useful to you.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Marks ? on unknown words and looks up two.	Emerging Marks ? and ★ and writes one margin note.	Progressing Uses all three marks and explains one arrow.	Challenge Annotates, then writes a question for the author.
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Try it this week

Teach the three marks with one short text. Collect the papers and look only at the question marks.

What a visitor would see

Texts with a few purposeful marks in the margins, and partners talking from them.

Match the Organizer to the Thinking

The shape of the chart is the shape of the idea.

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Why it works

A graphic organizer lets students show complex thinking with very little language. It only helps when its shape matches the thinking the task requires. The wrong organizer adds confusion instead of removing it.

How to do it

- 1 Name the thinking.**
Comparing? Sequencing? Cause and effect? Claim and evidence?
- 2 Choose the matching shape.**
Use the same shape every time for that kind of thinking.
- 3 Turn the chart into sentences.**
Each box becomes a sentence with the week's frame.

What it looks like

Compare	Two columns or overlapping circles: both ... , but ...
Sequence	A chain of boxes with arrows: first, next, finally
Cause and effect	Arrow from one box to another: because ... , as a result ...
Claim and evidence	One box on top, three underneath: I claim ... , the evidence is ...
Main idea	A table top with legs: the main idea is ... , one detail is ...

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Fills the organizer with words, labels, or drawings.	Emerging Fills it with phrases and says one sentence from it.	Progressing Writes a sentence for each box using the frame.	Challenge Chooses the right organizer without being told.
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Try it this week

Pick the one kind of thinking your unit needs most. Use its organizer three times this week.

What a visitor would see

The same few organizer shapes in use across the room, each followed by sentences.

Read Aloud, Think Aloud

Let them hear what a reader's mind does.

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Why it works

Students see the result of good reading but never the process. Two minutes of reading aloud while saying your thoughts shows them what to do when a sentence is hard. It also lets English learners hear how academic English sounds.

How to do it

- 1 Choose the hardest paragraph.**
Not the whole text. Two minutes.
- 2 Read it aloud and stop three times.**
"I'm not sure what that word means, so I'll look at the next sentence."
- 3 Hand it over.**
Partners do the same with the next paragraph.

In your subject

ELA	"The author says 'noble.' That seems too big. I think this is sarcasm."
Math	"It says 'at least.' That means this number or more, so I need the $\geq$ sign."
Science	"The graph goes up and then flat. I wonder what stopped the growth."
Social studies	"This was written in 1863, so 'the war' must mean the Civil War."
Any class	Name the strategy: reread, look around the word, check the picture, break it into parts.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Listens, follows with a finger, and repeats key phrases.	Emerging Echo-reads a sentence after the teacher.	Progressing Thinks aloud with a partner using a starter: "I'm thinking ..."	Challenge Models a think-aloud for a small group.
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Try it this week

Once this week, read your hardest paragraph aloud and say what you are thinking at three points.

What a visitor would see

A teacher reading a short passage aloud and pausing to explain their own thinking.

Build Background in Two Minutes

You cannot comprehend what you cannot picture.

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Why it works

A reading about the Dust Bowl is hard if you have never seen a prairie, however strong your English is. Much of what looks like a language problem is a background problem. Two minutes with an image fixes more than a vocabulary list does.

How to do it

- 1 Find one image, map, or thirty-second clip.**
Show it before the reading.
- 2 Ask what students notice and what it reminds them of.**
Answers in any language count.
- 3 Connect it to what they already know.**
Their home countries have droughts, migrations, elections, and rivers too.

In your subject

ELA	A photograph of the setting before a story set somewhere unfamiliar.
Math	A real receipt, pay stub, or floor plan before a word problem about one.
Science	A short clip of the phenomenon before the explanation of it.
Social studies	A map and a timeline before any primary source.
Any class	"Has anyone seen something like this? Where?" Then listen.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Names what they see in any language; learns three labels.	Emerging Describes the image with a frame: "I see ____."	Progressing Connects the image to the topic in a sentence.	Challenge Predicts what the text will say and checks the prediction.
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Try it this week

Before one reading this week, show a single image for two minutes and ask what students notice.

What a visitor would see

An image or map on the screen before the text appears, and students talking about it.

Look at the Work Together

Mid-year: who has moved, and who is stuck?

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Why it works

Half the year is gone. Some students have outgrown their supports and are being held back by them; others still need more. Twenty minutes looking at real student work, with one question in mind, tells a team more than any report.

How to do it

- 1 Bring one piece of work from an English learner.**
Something written this month.
- 2 Ask: what can this student do now that they could not in August?**
Start with strengths.
- 3 Decide one change.**
Remove a support, add one, or move the student up a lane.

What it looks like

Look for	Longer sentences, connecting words, subject vocabulary, self-correction.
Moving up	Uses the frame every time without help? Take the frame away.
Stuck	Same errors since August? Pick one and teach it directly.
Silent	Still not speaking? Check seating, partner, and whether the questions allow short answers.
Get help	Share a name and a work sample with your EL specialist and look at it together.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Compare: August labels and drawings with today's sentences.	Emerging Compare: framed sentences with today's independent ones.	Progressing Compare: single sentences with today's paragraphs.	Challenge Compare: correct paragraphs with today's precise, varied ones.
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Try it this week

Bring one piece of English learner work to your next team meeting. Decide one support to remove or add.

What a visitor would see

Teachers comparing a student's August and December work and adjusting supports.